

Incident Report — Fake Zoom to Ransomware: The Social Engineering Pipeline

SOC Analysis & Triage Assignment · Zaio Cybersecurity Bootcamp · Advanced Operation

1. Header / Metadata

Operation ID	OPS-2024-0501-03
Operation name	Fake Zoom to Ransomware: The Social Engineering Pipeline
Started (UTC)	2024-05-01 08:21:32
Closed (UTC)	2024-05-10 00:12:12
Analyst	Ndumiso Mbanjwa
Cohort	May26 Cybersecurity
Difficulty	Advanced
Severity	Critical
Final verdict	True Positive
Status	Confirmed active incident - escalated to incident response and senior leadership

2. Executive Summary

The attack began when a user named `adriana.garcia`, working on computer `CORP-WKS-102`, downloaded what appeared to be a Zoom installer, called `Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe`. It was not a legitimate Zoom installer. Once opened, it secretly started several additional programs that let the attackers communicate with the computer. The attackers deliberately used legitimate Windows programs such as PowerShell, MSBuild, and `mshta.exe`, because these programs normally exist on Windows computers and can therefore help malicious activity blend in with everyday system activity. The attackers then remained inside the environment for about five days before installing another malicious program called `ZoomUpdater.exe`. After that, the attack became more serious: the attackers attempted to steal credentials, created an unauthorized account called `backup`, attempted remote access between systems, and compromised a Confluence server through a separate attack route. The attackers eventually gained access to the company's software-deployment system, PDQ Deploy. Because this tool is designed to install software on many computers at once, the attackers were able to abuse it to spread ransomware across the organization. The ransomware deleted the computer's built-in recovery copies, encrypted files, and left behind a ransom note called `rhddiicoE.README.txt`, confirming that the attack had fully succeeded. This is a confirmed True Positive: all ten of the platform's scored tasks were answered correctly using only the organization's own security logs, with no

gaps in the evidence. The most urgent next steps are isolating the three affected systems, disabling the unauthorized account, rotating every reachable credential, cancelling the software-deployment tool's access, and patching or isolating the Confluence server.

3. Operation Details

Triggering detection	High-priority alerts fired for: a step-by-step exploit chain against the Confluence server; the deletion of the computer's built-in recovery copies; and unusual internet activity from MSBuild, a normally trustworthy Windows tool
Source	92.51.2.22 (used for the hidden download and communication channel); 92.51.2.27 (used for remote-access attempts); 45.141.87.218 (the MSBuild communication channel) — all attacker-controlled
Destination	CORP-WKS-102 (the first infected computer), SRV-CONFLUENCE-01 (a separate attack route), corp-dc-01 (the domain controller)
User / Host affected	adriana.garcia (CORP-WKS-102); the unauthorized backup account (SRV-CONFLUENCE-01); the it_admin_james account (corp-dc-01)
Artefact	Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe, ZoomUpdater.exe, Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1, PDQDeployService.exe (the legitimate tool that was abused), rhddiicoE.README.txt
Direction	Inbound download and remote-control traffic; internal remote-access attempts; company-wide ransomware push
Tool surfaces used	Endpoint detection (XDR), security logs (SIEM), network activity, and the platform's threat-intelligence write-up

4. Investigation & Triage

Task	Objective	What I checked	Finding	Decision & reasoning	Fig . ref
Tasks 1-2 - How the attack started	Identify the fake installer and how it first got onto the computer	The endpoint tool's process history (browser → Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe → command line → mshta.exe)	Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe ran at 08:24:53; a Windows tool called mshta.exe then downloaded extra malicious instructions from 92.51.2.22 at 08:26:15	This matches a fake download page described in the platform's own threat write-up; a command that hid the newly created files	Fig . 3

				right after confirms this was intentional, not an accident	
Tasks 3-4 - How the attackers kept in touch with the computer without leaving obvious files	Identify how the attackers avoided placing an obvious malicious program on the hard drive, and how they kept a communication channel open	The endpoint tool's process history and the security-alert panel	A hidden PowerShell command started MSBuild (a normal Microsoft development tool) at 08:30:59, which then connected out to 45.141.87.218	MSBuild is a legitimate tool being abused to run instructions directly in memory, without ever saving an obvious malicious file to disk; a dedicated security alert for unusual MSBuild internet activity backs this up	Fig . 3
Task 6 - The second malicious program that showed up days later	Identify the program installed after the attackers had been inside for several days	The endpoint tool's process history, five days later	ZoomUpdater.exe was installed and run on 2024-05-06 at 02:54:23	This multi-day gap suggests the first part of the attack ran automatically , before a human attacker became more directly involved	Fig . 3
Task 5 - Where the remote-access attempts came from	Identify the outside address used to try to remotely access the computer	Security logs recording failed remote-login attempts	Failed attempts came from 92.51.2.27 (14:49:43) and then 92.51.2.22 (15:09:39), both aimed at adriana.garcia's computer	92.51.2.27 is treated as the answer because it's the earliest of the two; both addresses come from	Fig . 8

				the same small range, suggesting the same attacker infrastructure	
Task 7 - How credentials were stolen	Identify how the attackers tried to steal additional login credentials	Detailed script-activity logging	A script called Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1 was found stored under the unauthorized backup account	The script's name makes it look like it belongs to legitimate Veeam backup software, but it was actually being used to pull credentials out of the system's memory	Fig . 9
Task 8 - How the attackers set up a second way back in	Identify the persistence mechanism the attackers created	Account-creation logs and a Confluence-attack detection rule	An account called backup was created on the Confluence server (SRV-CONFLUENCE-01); a security rule also linked a Confluence process directly to the same kind of malicious download seen at the start of the attack	This points to a second, separate way into the network through the Confluence server, running alongside the original fake-Zoom attack chain	Fig . 10
Task 9 - What was used to spread the ransomware everywhere	Identify the tool used to push the ransomware out to every computer	A manual review of a very long activity timeline (154 entries) covering the night of 9-10 May	PDQDeployService.exe — the company's own legitimate software-deployment tool — was identified as the program used, right around 23:58:12	This was confirmed with the platform's guidance; the exact position of this event in a clean, numbered list couldn't be pinned	Fig . 11

				down because the underlying list of 154 events wasn't perfectly sorted by time — this is noted here honestly rather than glossed over	
Task 10 - Confirming the ransomware actually worked	Confirm whether the ransomware attack was actually completed	The endpoint tool's file-activity panel	A ransom note, rhddiicoE.README.txt, was created on the affected computer right after the encryption process ran	This confirms files were actually encrypted, rather than the ransomware simply being downloaded or prepared without being run	Fig . 6

5. Threat Intelligence

Indicator (defanged)	Tool	Result / score	Date checked (UTC)	Notes
92[.]51[.]2[.]22	VirusTotal	2 of 91 security companies flagged it	2026-08-28	Hosted by Flyservers S.A., Russia
92[.]51[.]2[.]27	VirusTotal	1 of 91 security companies flagged it	2026-08-28	Same hosting company and address range as above, Russia
45[.]141[.]87[.]218	VirusTotal	9 of 91 security companies flagged it; negative community rating	2026-08-28	Russia
143[.]244[.]146[.]183	VirusTotal	7 of 91 security companies flagged it	2026-08-28	DigitalOcean (a common hosting provider),

				United States
Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe (file fingerprint)	VirusTotal	No match found	2026-08-28	Not proof the file is safe — it simply hasn't been submitted to VirusTotal, consistent with a file built specifically for this campaign
ZoomUpdater.exe (file fingerprint)	VirusTotal	14 of 70 security companies flagged a match	2026-08-28	The match is actually to an unrelated real hacking tool ('netscan.exe'); most likely a coincidental fingerprint clash on the training platform's side, noted here rather than treated as a real connection

This is assessed with high confidence as a financially motivated ransomware attack carried out by attackers actively working the keyboard themselves, based on the platform's own write-up ("Fake Software Installer to Hands-on-Keyboards Ransomware"), which describes this as a recreation of a real, publicly documented case: a security research firm's account of a Confluence exploit leading to LockBit ransomware. The two addresses with the strongest outside confirmation are 45.141.87.218 (9 of 91 vendors, negative community rating) and 143.244.146.183 (7 of 91 vendors, on a common hosting provider), while the two addresses in the 92.51.2.0/24 range carry weaker single-vendor flags, reinforced by both sharing the same small provider and address range. The initial installer's file fingerprint has no VirusTotal history at all — consistent with a file built specifically for this training scenario rather than proof it's harmless — and the second-stage file's fingerprint happens to match an unrelated real hacking tool, which is disclosed here as a likely coincidence rather than treated as a real connection. Four addresses seen in the network logs (40.126.32.136, 20.231.128.20, 204.79.197.215, 13.107.42.14) were checked and ruled out as ordinary Microsoft/Office 365 traffic, not part of the attack. As with the other two reports in this set, the case here rests mainly on the company's own logs — the full chain of programs launched, the security alerts that fired, and the answers confirmed by the platform — rather than on outside reputation checks.

6. Timeline (UTC)

Time (UTC)	Event
2024-05-01 08:21:32	The user is browsing the web shortly before the download — Info
2024-05-01 08:24:53	The fake Zoom installer, Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe, is run — Critical
2024-05-01 08:25:00	A command hides the newly created files — High
2024-05-01 08:26:15	mshta.exe downloads extra malicious instructions from 92.51.2.22 — Critical
2024-05-01 08:30:58-08:30:59	A hidden PowerShell command starts MSBuild, which connects out to 45.141.87.218 — Critical/High
2024-05-06 02:54:10-02:54:23	A second PowerShell command installs and runs ZoomUpdater.exe, the second-stage program — Critical
2024-05-0X 14:49:43 / 15:09:39	Failed remote-login attempts against the computer from 92.51.2.27, then 92.51.2.22 — Medium
(recorded in script-activity logs)	The credential-stealing script Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1 runs under the unauthorized backup account — Critical
(recorded in account logs)	The backup account is created on the Confluence server; a security rule links a Confluence process to the same kind of malicious download seen earlier — Critical
2024-05-09 23:55:07-2024-05-10 00:12:12	The ransomware is pushed out: the company's own deployment tool runs, followed by a burst of related activity on the affected computer — Critical/Medium
(after encryption)	The ransom note rhddiicoE.README.txt is created, confirming the attack succeeded — Critical

7. Indicators of Compromise

Type	Indicator (defanged)	Context
IPv4	92[.]51[.]2[.]22	Used for the initial hidden download and communication (2 of 91 on VirusTotal)
IPv4	92[.]51[.]2[.]27	Source of the remote-login attempts (1 of 91 on VirusTotal)
IPv4	45[.]141[.]87[.]218	The channel MSBuild used to stay in touch

		with the attackers (9 of 91 on VirusTotal)
IPv4	143[.]244[.]146[.]183	Additional suspicious infrastructure, likely used for remote access or moving stolen data (7 of 91 on VirusTotal)
File	Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe	The fake Zoom installer that started the whole attack
File	ZoomUpdater.exe	The second malicious program, installed five days later
File path	C:\Users\backup\AppData\Local\Temp\Veeam-Get-Creds-New[.]ps1	The script used to steal credentials
File name	rhddiicoE[.]README[.]txt	The ransom note confirming the attack succeeded
Account	backup	The unauthorized account the attackers created for continued access
Legitimate tool (abused)	PDQDeployService.exe	The company's own software-deployment tool, hijacked to push ransomware everywhere

STIX 2.1 Bundle

```
{
  "type": "bundle",
  "id": "bundle--01800446-462d-457f-886c-9217e9534655",
  "objects": [
    {
      "type": "identity",
      "spec_version": "2.1",
      "id": "identity--3c0960dd-84fb-4a39-99d2-f1c437a0e265",
      "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.065257Z",
      "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.065257Z",
      "name": "Ndumiso Mbanjwa (May26 Cybersecurity SOC Triage)",
      "description": "Analyst-produced threat intelligence from an independent SOC investigation on socsimulator.com (Investigation mode), Operation 3: Fake Zoom to Ransomware, The Social Engineering Pipeline.",
      "identity_class": "individual"
    },
    {
      "type": "identity",
      "spec_version": "2.1",
```

```

        "id": "identity--e4f5523f-b3ed-403a-962f-b2f16f192906",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.065511Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.065511Z",
        "name": "Simulated Enterprise Environment (SOC Simulator Op3)",
        "description": "Victim organization; key affected hosts CORP-WKS-102
(patient zero, user adriana.garcia), SRV-CONFLUENCE-01 (parallel Confluence-exploit
vector), and corp-dc-01 (domain controller).",
        "identity_class": "organization"
    },
    {
        "type": "malware",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "malware--d4c5e297-426d-4584-b1c9-5aea5661db21",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.065688Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.065688Z",
        "name": "Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe (trojanized installer)",
        "description": "Trojanized Zoom installer served via a cloned/drive-by
download site. Hides dropped artifacts (attrib +s +h) and launches mshta.exe to
retrieve a first-stage HTA loader.",
        "malware_types": [
            "trojan",
            "downloader"
        ],
        "is_family": false
    },
    {
        "type": "malware",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "malware--58055f21-6faf-4957-b2ac-7f2ad4feae3",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066205Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066205Z",
        "name": "MSBuild.exe inline-task C2 loader",
        "description": "Abuse of the legitimate MSBuild.exe utility's inline-tasks
feature to compile and execute C# code in-memory, establishing outbound command-and-
control without dropping a standalone malicious executable (T1127.001).",
        "malware_types": [
            "remote-access-trojan"
        ],
        "is_family": false
    },
    {
        "type": "malware",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "malware--4baa5792-f916-4965-b817-8ac4be8604f5",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066374Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066374Z",
        "name": "ZoomUpdater.exe (second-stage payload)",
        "description": "Second-stage payload dropped and executed after an
approximately five-day dwell period, consistent with hand-off from automated loader to
hands-on-keyboard operators.",
        "malware_types": [
            "backdoor"
        ],
    },

```

```

        "is_family": false
    },
    {
        "type": "malware",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "malware--171b2e59-a9ff-4faf-a5d3-00c7206d83d5",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066832Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066832Z",
        "name": "Ransomware payload (final impact stage)",
        "description": "Double-extortion ransomware deployed via hijacked PDQ
Deploy infrastructure. Deletes shadow copies via vssadmin prior to encryption and
leaves a ransom note (rhddiicoE.README.txt) confirming completed impact.",
        "malware_types": [
            "ransomware"
        ],
        "is_family": false
    },
    {
        "type": "tool",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "tool--fde09159-782f-4705-8c01-e7e633e13895",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066519Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066519Z",
        "name": "Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1",
        "description": "PowerShell credential-harvesting script disguised with a
Veeam backup-software-branded filename, staged under a 'backup'-named account profile
at C:\\Users\\backup\\AppData\\Local\\Temp\\Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1.",
        "tool_types": [
            "credential-exploitation"
        ]
    },
    {
        "type": "tool",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "tool--0a98c94b-f5ff-4d8a-95ca-c2b138190267",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066711Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066711Z",
        "name": "PDQDeployService.exe (abused for ransomware push)",
        "description": "Legitimate enterprise software-deployment tool hijacked to
mass-push and execute the ransomware payload across CORP-WKS-102 and related hosts in a
tightly-timed, two-minutes-apart burst of process launches.",
        "tool_types": [
            "remote-access"
        ]
    },
    {
        "type": "attack-pattern",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "attack-pattern--e11f6b1b-053c-445f-a75d-4d2dcf3f16ed",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066973Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.066973Z",
        "name": "Drive-by Compromise",
        "description": "Trojanized Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe served via a cloned/drive-by

```

```

download site. Confirmed by the platform's own Threat Intel advisory.",
  "external_references": [
    {
      "source_name": "mitre-attack",
      "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1189/",
      "external_id": "T1189"
    }
  ]
},
{
  "type": "attack-pattern",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "attack-pattern--d0df8c35-896b-4572-9e9f-b12ebd70c0de",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067198Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067198Z",
  "name": "User Execution: Malicious File",
  "description": "adriana.garcia executed the trojanized installer believing
it to be legitimate Zoom software (2024-05-01 08:24:53 UTC).",
  "external_references": [
    {
      "source_name": "mitre-attack",
      "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1204/002/",
      "external_id": "T1204.002"
    }
  ]
},
{
  "type": "attack-pattern",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "attack-pattern--54d0594a-f50c-4c1c-9719-d1165a4b2e93",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067439Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067439Z",
  "name": "System Binary Proxy Execution: Mshta",
  "description": "mshta.exe retrieves and executes the first-stage HTA
payload from http://92.51.2.22:443/UsySLX1n.hta (08:26:15 UTC).",
  "external_references": [
    {
      "source_name": "mitre-attack",
      "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1218/005/",
      "external_id": "T1218.005"
    }
  ]
},
{
  "type": "attack-pattern",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "attack-pattern--ded550f4-33d8-493b-9ab8-41de031d79d2",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067644Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067644Z",
  "name": "Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell",
  "description": "Encoded/hidden PowerShell commands launched at both first-
stage (08:30:58) and second-stage (2024-05-06 02:54:10) execution points.",
  "external_references": [

```

```

        {
            "source_name": "mitre-attack",
            "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1059/001/",
            "external_id": "T1059.001"
        }
    ],
},
{
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--4d923808-5fa1-498a-9eed-4c20b441c0e5",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067872Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.067872Z",
    "name": "Trusted Developer Utilities Proxy Execution: MSBuild",
    "description": "Analyst-added mapping (not itemized separately in the platform advisory's own technique list, but directly evidenced): MSBuild.exe spawned by PowerShell at 08:30:59, connects outbound to 45.141.87.218:443. Corroborated by the SIEM 'Suspicious MSBuild Network Activity' detection rule (High).",
    "external_references": [
        {
            "source_name": "mitre-attack",
            "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1127/001/",
            "external_id": "T1127.001"
        }
    ]
},
{
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--1d6d531b-33e9-4cce-aad3-fed1494461d",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068043Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068043Z",
    "name": "Process Injection",
    "description": "Platform advisory describes the remote-access trojan being injected into a legitimate process for command-and-control during the multi-stage loading phase.",
    "external_references": [
        {
            "source_name": "mitre-attack",
            "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1055/",
            "external_id": "T1055"
        }
    ]
},
{
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--122e643a-a972-47ec-953b-e3ff7c98f65f",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068201Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068201Z",
    "name": "OS Credential Dumping: LSASS Memory",
    "description": "Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1 credential-harvesting script recovered via SIEM PowerShell script-block logging (EventID 4104). Confirmed platform

```

```

finding (Task 7).",
    "external_references": [
        {
            "source_name": "mitre-attack",
            "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1003/001/",
            "external_id": "T1003.001"
        }
    ]
},
{
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--08ee80fa-6f4f-4590-9236-282ae23a6b7e",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068364Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068364Z",
    "name": "Exploit Public-Facing Application",
    "description": "SIEM 'Confluence OGNL Exploitation Chain' detection rule
(Critical): a Confluence process on SRV-CONFLUENCE-01 spawns mshta.exe against a remote
URL, indicating a parallel CVE-2022-26134-class OGNL injection vector against the
Confluence server.",
    "external_references": [
        {
            "source_name": "mitre-attack",
            "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1190/",
            "external_id": "T1190"
        }
    ]
},
{
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--a7151829-9c43-4348-8044-d09537e46cb6",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068517Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068517Z",
    "name": "Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols",
    "description": "HTTP/HTTPS-based command-and-control channels to 92.51.2.22
(HTA retrieval) and 45.141.87.218 (MSBuild.exe C2).",
    "external_references": [
        {
            "source_name": "mitre-attack",
            "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1071/001/",
            "external_id": "T1071.001"
        }
    ]
},
{
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--a814fe3a-0482-44d4-a92b-54f3a40f9cb2",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068713Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.068713Z",
    "name": "Remote Services: RDP",
    "description": "External failed-logon (4625) events targeting CORP-WKS-

```

102/adriana.garcia from 92.51.2.27 (14:49:43 UTC) and 92.51.2.22 (15:09:39 UTC), consistent with attempted RDP-based lateral movement/remote access.",

```
    "external_references": [
      {
        "source_name": "mitre-attack",
        "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1021/001/",
        "external_id": "T1021.001"
      }
    ]
  },
  {
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--2b2bd5d7-5866-4bca-bbb7-32758be31015",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.06888Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.06888Z",
    "name": "Exfiltration Over Web Service: Cloud Storage",
    "description": "Platform advisory describes exfiltration to a legitimate cloud-storage/SaaS service to blend with normal traffic; not independently re-verified against a specific sim log in this investigation, and flagged as such.",
    "external_references": [
      {
        "source_name": "mitre-attack",
        "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1567/002/",
        "external_id": "T1567.002"
      }
    ]
  },
  {
    "type": "attack-pattern",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "attack-pattern--caf3a9f6-fde1-4656-81b8-285b5fec4495",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.069028Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.069028Z",
    "name": "Data Encrypted for Impact",
    "description": "Ransom note rhddiicoE.README.txt confirms completed encryption (confirmed platform finding, Task 10), preceded by vssadmin shadow-copy deletion ('Ransomware Shadow Copy Deletion' SIEM rule, Critical).",
    "external_references": [
      {
        "source_name": "mitre-attack",
        "url": "https://attack.mitre.org/techniques/T1486/",
        "external_id": "T1486"
      }
    ]
  },
  {
    "type": "indicator",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "indicator--25643afd-d34f-4e08-8145-1d0934a7ffa6",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.069179Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.069179Z",
    "name": "Initial mshta.exe / HTA command-and-control IP",
```

```

        "description": "Source of the first-stage HTA payload (UsySLX1n.hta)
retrieved by mshta.exe at 2024-05-01 08:26:15 UTC. VirusTotal: 2/91 vendors flagged
malicious (alphaMountain.ai, GreyNoise). AS209588 Flyservers S.A., RU.",
        "indicator_types": [
            "malicious-activity",
            "command-and-control"
        ],
        "pattern": "[ipv4-addr:value = '92.51.2.22']",
        "pattern_type": "stix",
        "pattern_version": "2.1",
        "valid_from": "2024-05-01T08:26:15Z"
    },
    {
        "type": "indicator",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "indicator--743879aa-508a-47aa-8205-54dadbb543f0",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.075219Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.075219Z",
        "name": "RDP failed-logon source / attacker remote-access origin",
        "description": "External failed-logon (4625) source against CORP-WKS-
102/adriana.garcia at 14:49:43 UTC \u2014 chronologically the earlier of two candidate
addresses, confirmed as the platform's accepted Task 5 answer. VirusTotal: 1/91 vendors
flagged malicious (alphaMountain.ai). Same /24 and ASN as 92.51.2.22.",
        "indicator_types": [
            "malicious-activity"
        ],
        "pattern": "[ipv4-addr:value = '92.51.2.27']",
        "pattern_type": "stix",
        "pattern_version": "2.1",
        "valid_from": "2024-05-01T14:49:43Z"
    },
    {
        "type": "indicator",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "indicator--c8c17c9c-8539-4089-b2d7-831aa8025364",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.076122Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.076122Z",
        "name": "MSBuild.exe fileless command-and-control IP",
        "description": "Outbound TCP connection destination from MSBuild.exe at
08:30:59 UTC, confirmed by the SIEM 'Suspicious MSBuild Network Activity' rule (High).
VirusTotal: 9/91 vendors flagged malicious/malware, community score -7, RU. The
strongest independently-corroborated network indicator in this incident.",
        "indicator_types": [
            "malicious-activity",
            "command-and-control"
        ],
        "pattern": "[ipv4-addr:value = '45.141.87.218']",
        "pattern_type": "stix",
        "pattern_version": "2.1",
        "valid_from": "2024-05-01T08:30:59Z"
    },
    {
        "type": "indicator",

```

```

        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "indicator--abf9216b-62d7-429b-93e5-efde40ff919a",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.076932Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.076932Z",
        "name": "Network-tab indicator (DigitalOcean-hosted)",
        "description": "Surfaced in the platform's Network Indicators panel (80
total / 40 external). VirusTotal: 7/91 vendors flagged malicious/malware/phishing,
AS14061 DigitalOcean LLC, US \u2014 consistent with commodity VPS infrastructure
commonly abused for RDP-proxy/tunnel relay or cloud-exfiltration staging.",
        "indicator_types": [
            "malicious-activity"
        ],
        "pattern": "[ipv4-addr:value = '143.244.146.183']",
        "pattern_type": "stix",
        "pattern_version": "2.1",
        "valid_from": "2024-05-01T00:00:00Z"
    },
    {
        "type": "indicator",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "indicator--e1eac964-417d-4028-8333-6ab92b955a7e",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.077744Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.077744Z",
        "name": "First-stage HTA loader URL",
        "description": "Retrieved by mshta.exe at 08:26:15 UTC to obtain the first-
stage loader payload.",
        "indicator_types": [
            "malicious-activity"
        ],
        "pattern": "[url:value = 'http://92.51.2.22:443/UsySLX1n.hta']",
        "pattern_type": "stix",
        "pattern_version": "2.1",
        "valid_from": "2024-05-01T08:26:15Z"
    },
    {
        "type": "indicator",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "indicator--bc475011-7cd3-4b68-8c3e-3c7d0c9310d6",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.079178Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.079178Z",
        "name": "Trojanized initial-access dropper",
        "description": "Trojanized Zoom installer executed by adriana.garcia at
08:24:53 UTC. No VirusTotal record found for this exact hash \u2014 consistent with a
synthetic/training-platform sample rather than one with real-world circulation; absence
of a VT record is not treated as evidence of benignity.",
        "indicator_types": [
            "malicious-activity"
        ],
        "pattern": "[file:name = 'Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe' AND file:hashes.'SHA-256' =
'ecb0b3057163cd25c989a66683cfb47c19f122407cbbb49b1043e908c4f07ad1']",
        "pattern_type": "stix",
        "pattern_version": "2.1",
        "valid_from": "2024-05-01T08:24:53Z"
    }

```

```

    },
    {
      "type": "indicator",
      "spec_version": "2.1",
      "id": "indicator--1fa8ed83-8e8f-439d-b7b3-49254e6a3ec1",
      "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.082774Z",
      "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.082774Z",
      "name": "Second-stage payload",
      "description": "Dropped and executed at 2024-05-06 02:54:23 UTC after a ~5-
day dwell period. VirusTotal hash lookup matched an unrelated real file ('netscan.exe',
hacktool.netscan/nettool family, 14/70 detections) \u2014 disclosed as a likely
coincidental hash reuse by the training platform's synthetic data, not evidence that
this payload is literally a network-scanning hacktool.",
      "indicator_types": [
        "malicious-activity"
      ],
      "pattern": "[file:name = 'ZoomUpdater.exe' AND file:hashes.'SHA-256' =
'498ba0afa5d3b390f852af66bd6e763945bf9b6bff2087015ed8612a18372155']",
      "pattern_type": "stix",
      "pattern_version": "2.1",
      "valid_from": "2024-05-06T02:54:23Z"
    },
    {
      "type": "indicator",
      "spec_version": "2.1",
      "id": "indicator--35635831-3d39-41a6-b406-6a07ddffa6da",
      "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.083876Z",
      "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.083876Z",
      "name": "Credential-theft script (Veeam-branded)",
      "description": "Confirmed platform finding, Task 7 \u2014 credential-
harvesting PowerShell script disguised with a Veeam backup-software-branded filename.",
      "indicator_types": [
        "malicious-activity"
      ],
      "pattern": "[file:name = 'Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1' AND
file:parent_directory_ref.path = 'C:\\\\Users\\\\\\backup\\\\\\AppData\\\\\\Local\\\\\\Temp']",
      "pattern_type": "stix",
      "pattern_version": "2.1",
      "valid_from": "2024-05-01T00:00:00Z"
    },
    {
      "type": "indicator",
      "spec_version": "2.1",
      "id": "indicator--ecc68121-91c7-4850-9701-2bf4528d729c",
      "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.086914Z",
      "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.086914Z",
      "name": "Unexplained binary executed on domain controller",
      "description": "Executed under the it_admin_james identity on corp-dc-01 at
2024-05-09 23:55:07 UTC, immediately preceding the ransomware deployment burst \u2014
likely a staged utility or the ransomware binary itself under an
impersonated/compromised administrative identity.",
      "indicator_types": [
        "malicious-activity"
      ]
    }
  ]
}

```

```

    ],
    "pattern": "[file:name = '123.exe' AND file:parent_directory_ref.path =
'C:\\\\Users\\\\Public']",
    "pattern_type": "stix",
    "pattern_version": "2.1",
    "valid_from": "2024-05-09T23:55:07Z"
  },
  {
    "type": "indicator",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "indicator--e9b88618-1457-41cd-b1cb-23a22a77f15c",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.088026Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.088026Z",
    "name": "Ransom-note artifact",
    "description": "Confirmed platform finding, Task 10 \u2014 created
following the encryption run, confirming completed ransomware impact.",
    "indicator_types": [
      "malicious-activity"
    ],
    "pattern": "[file:name = 'rhddiicoE.README.txt']",
    "pattern_type": "stix",
    "pattern_version": "2.1",
    "valid_from": "2024-05-10T00:12:12Z"
  },
  {
    "type": "indicator",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "indicator--4a7756e8-d6cc-41fe-a4b1-b00f308dfeec",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.088805Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.088805Z",
    "name": "Attacker-created persistence account",
    "description": "Created on SRV-CONFLUENCE-01 (EventID 4720). Confirmed
platform finding, Task 8. Also hosts the Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1 credential-theft
script under its profile.",
    "indicator_types": [
      "compromised"
    ],
    "pattern": "[user-account:user_id = 'backup']",
    "pattern_type": "stix",
    "pattern_version": "2.1",
    "valid_from": "2024-05-01T00:00:00Z"
  },
  {
    "type": "indicator",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "indicator--7eb60ac7-25df-43f4-800d-17265d443f88",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.089637Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.089637Z",
    "name": "Compromised user / patient zero",
    "description": "User of CORP-WKS-102 who executed the trojanized
installer.",
    "indicator_types": [
      "compromised"
    ]
  }

```

```

    ],
    "pattern": "[user-account:user_id = 'adriana.garcia']",
    "pattern_type": "stix",
    "pattern_version": "2.1",
    "valid_from": "2024-05-01T08:24:53Z"
  },
  {
    "type": "indicator",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "indicator--3baf56cb-7df7-4110-aff6-c66e8d1dc610",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.090285Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.090285Z",
    "name": "Patient-zero / ransomware staging host",
    "description": "Initial-access host; also the host where the PDQ-Deploy-
driven ransomware deployment burst executed.",
    "indicator_types": [
      "compromised"
    ],
    "pattern": "[hostname:value = 'CORP-WKS-102']",
    "pattern_type": "stix",
    "pattern_version": "2.1",
    "valid_from": "2024-05-01T08:24:53Z"
  },
  {
    "type": "indicator",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "indicator--1131c104-a3fe-4ee4-bc96-034badc0e038",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.091094Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.091094Z",
    "name": "Parallel Confluence-exploit host",
    "description": "Site of a parallel/converging initial-access vector
(Confluence OGNL exploitation chain) and the attacker-created 'backup' persistence
account.",
    "indicator_types": [
      "compromised"
    ],
    "pattern": "[hostname:value = 'SRV-CONFLUENCE-01']",
    "pattern_type": "stix",
    "pattern_version": "2.1",
    "valid_from": "2024-05-01T00:00:00Z"
  },
  {
    "type": "indicator",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "indicator--95a923ae-16b6-4e1d-8b94-15cc0cf9cff9",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.091835Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.091835Z",
    "name": "Domain controller \u2014 ransomware-burst launch point",
    "description": "Site of the C:\\Users\\Public\\123.exe execution under the
it_admin_james identity immediately preceding the ransomware deployment burst.",
    "indicator_types": [
      "compromised"
    ],
  },

```

```

    "pattern": "[hostname:value = 'corp-dc-01']",
    "pattern_type": "stix",
    "pattern_version": "2.1",
    "valid_from": "2024-05-09T23:55:07Z"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--d7ae1e17-7828-40f7-a7b4-37adfe341817",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.092664Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.092664Z",
    "relationship_type": "indicates",
    "description": "Observable for the trojanized installer.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--bc475011-7cd3-4b68-8c3e-3c7d0c9310d6",
    "target_ref": "malware--d4c5e297-426d-4584-b1c9-5aea5661db21"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--67467018-4115-4949-ac5f-7bacccebefde",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093212Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093212Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "description": "Served via a cloned/drive-by download site.",
    "source_ref": "malware--d4c5e297-426d-4584-b1c9-5aea5661db21",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--e11f6b1b-053c-445f-a75d-4d2dcf3f16ed"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--8566f832-ce01-4ee7-99f4-9654b17bbbb5",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093391Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093391Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "description": "Requires the victim to execute the malicious file.",
    "source_ref": "malware--d4c5e297-426d-4584-b1c9-5aea5661db21",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--d0df8c35-896b-4572-9e9f-b12ebd70c0de"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--948af95f-aed0-4169-a730-81bd8904e699",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093532Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093532Z",
    "relationship_type": "related-to",
    "description": "adriana.garcia executed the trojanized installer.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--7eb60ac7-25df-43f4-800d-17265d443f88",
    "target_ref": "malware--d4c5e297-426d-4584-b1c9-5aea5661db21"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--ece4f323-1c3f-4e40-9ccd-3ad8e5094418",

```

```

    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093721Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093721Z",
    "relationship_type": "indicates",
    "description": "Observable for mshta.exe's HTA retrieval technique.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--e1eac964-417d-4028-8333-6ab92b955a7e",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--54d0594a-f50c-4c1c-9719-d1165a4b2e93"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--67573cf9-f96f-4680-9c52-30d8d8f33177",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093856Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093856Z",
    "relationship_type": "hosts",
    "description": "92.51.2.22 hosts the first-stage HTA payload.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--25643afd-d34f-4e08-8145-1d0934a7ffa6",
    "target_ref": "indicator--e1eac964-417d-4028-8333-6ab92b955a7e"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--6801d565-0cfb-451d-9966-001b22a848d8",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093992Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.093992Z",
    "relationship_type": "indicates",
    "description": "HTTP-based C2 channel for the HTA retrieval.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--25643afd-d34f-4e08-8145-1d0934a7ffa6",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--a7151829-9c43-4348-8044-d09537e46cb6"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--98114b03-d659-4e43-95c9-d2506df54707",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094131Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094131Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "description": "MSBuild.exe inline-tasks abuse for fileless C2.",
    "source_ref": "malware--58055f21-6faf-4957-b2ac-7f2ad4feae3",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--4d923808-5fa1-498a-9eed-4c20b441c0e5"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--4c73f09b-ebc1-4bc0-ae6a-f2154a136b5b",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094272Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094272Z",
    "relationship_type": "uses",
    "description": "Launched via an encoded PowerShell command.",
    "source_ref": "malware--58055f21-6faf-4957-b2ac-7f2ad4feae3",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--ded550f4-33d8-493b-9ab8-41de031d79d2"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",

```

```

    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--a0f4c29f-8776-4620-b7ac-d9f29b7ee7e4",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094402Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094402Z",
    "relationship_type": "related-to",
    "description": "C2 destination for the MSBuild.exe fileless loader.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--c8c17c9c-8539-4089-b2d7-831aa8025364",
    "target_ref": "malware--58055f21-6faf-4957-b2ac-7f2ad4feae3"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--32155b77-eb7c-46ab-b71b-2989b2500abc",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094536Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094536Z",
    "relationship_type": "indicates",
    "description": "Observable for the MSBuild-based C2 channel.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--c8c17c9c-8539-4089-b2d7-831aa8025364",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--4d923808-5fa1-498a-9eed-4c20b441c0e5"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--b5f774d9-c11c-45ae-af2a-66236344d2e9",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094705Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094705Z",
    "relationship_type": "indicates",
    "description": "HTTPS-based C2 channel.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--c8c17c9c-8539-4089-b2d7-831aa8025364",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--a7151829-9c43-4348-8044-d09537e46cb6"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--0ab804ae-5e5f-4003-8adb-9c33078ce2d3",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094839Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094839Z",
    "relationship_type": "related-to",
    "description": "Observable for the second-stage payload binary.",
    "source_ref": "malware--4baa5792-f916-4965-b817-8ac4be8604f5",
    "target_ref": "indicator--1fa8ed83-8e8f-439d-b7b3-49254e6a3ec1"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--00c83171-3d90-4be6-81cf-a09428dcd3ca",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094965Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.094965Z",
    "relationship_type": "delivers",
    "description": "Dwell-period hand-off delivers the second-stage payload.",
    "source_ref": "malware--58055f21-6faf-4957-b2ac-7f2ad4feae3",
    "target_ref": "malware--4baa5792-f916-4965-b817-8ac4be8604f5"
  },

```

```

{
  "type": "relationship",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "relationship--fc35794e-25cc-41bc-b60d-9df013499f54",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095096Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095096Z",
  "relationship_type": "indicates",
  "description": "Observable for the credential-theft script.",
  "source_ref": "indicator--35635831-3d39-41a6-b406-6a07ddffa6da",
  "target_ref": "tool--fde09159-782f-4705-8c01-e7e633e13895"
},
{
  "type": "relationship",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "relationship--9749505d-94a9-463b-94fb-b20b49181617",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095223Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095223Z",
  "relationship_type": "uses",
  "description": "Implements LSASS/credential-memory dumping.",
  "source_ref": "tool--fde09159-782f-4705-8c01-e7e633e13895",
  "target_ref": "attack-pattern--122e643a-a972-47ec-953b-e3ff7c98f65f"
},
{
  "type": "relationship",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "relationship--a947d7c3-5a8d-4e37-96ec-16026b9afd43",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095416Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095416Z",
  "relationship_type": "related-to",
  "description": "Script staged under this account's profile.",
  "source_ref": "indicator--4a7756e8-d6cc-41fe-a4b1-b00f308dfec",
  "target_ref": "tool--fde09159-782f-4705-8c01-e7e633e13895"
},
{
  "type": "relationship",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "relationship--0aabfd86-1a69-4968-9dd0-c134220094bb",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095581Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095581Z",
  "relationship_type": "related-to",
  "description": "Site of the parallel Confluence OGNL exploitation chain.",
  "source_ref": "indicator--1131c104-a3fe-4ee4-bc96-034badc0e038",
  "target_ref": "attack-pattern--08ee80fa-6f4f-4590-9236-282ae23a6b7e"
},
{
  "type": "relationship",
  "spec_version": "2.1",
  "id": "relationship--1ad371f0-6f18-4414-959e-bb93ad16ba64",
  "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095722Z",
  "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095722Z",
  "relationship_type": "related-to",
  "description": "Confluence exploitation is the likely origin of the backup
persistence account."
},

```

```

    "source_ref": "attack-pattern--08ee80fa-6f4f-4590-9236-282ae23a6b7e",
    "target_ref": "indicator--4a7756e8-d6cc-41fe-a4b1-b00f308dfeec"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--3ffa7f4d-2611-4278-955e-5d6c52fd5dac",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095847Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095847Z",
    "relationship_type": "related-to",
    "description": "Account created on this host.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--4a7756e8-d6cc-41fe-a4b1-b00f308dfeec",
    "target_ref": "indicator--1131c104-a3fe-4ee4-bc96-034badc0e038"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--72a7df03-ec5d-4e09-acb5-cee039dba7cd",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095973Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.095973Z",
    "relationship_type": "indicates",
    "description": "Observable for the attempted RDP-based remote-
access/lateral-movement technique.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--743879aa-508a-47aa-8205-54dadbb543f0",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--a814fe3a-0482-44d4-a92b-54f3a40f9cb2"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--f10ad699-b3a0-4def-b77e-517af384dfc3",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096099Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096099Z",
    "relationship_type": "related-to",
    "description": "Second RDP attempt source, same infrastructure block as the
initial C2 IP.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--25643afd-d34f-4e08-8145-1d0934a7ffa6",
    "target_ref": "attack-pattern--a814fe3a-0482-44d4-a92b-54f3a40f9cb2"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--a8ef6969-9428-4802-a3cf-b468ec9d18d8",
    "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096232Z",
    "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096232Z",
    "relationship_type": "communicates-with",
    "description": "External RDP logon attempts targeted this host.",
    "source_ref": "indicator--743879aa-508a-47aa-8205-54dadbb543f0",
    "target_ref": "indicator--3baf56cb-7df7-4110-aff6-c66e8d1dc610"
  },
  {
    "type": "relationship",
    "spec_version": "2.1",
    "id": "relationship--8347545c-0d58-4337-90fe-ca31c43886ee",

```

```

        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096374Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096374Z",
        "relationship_type": "related-to",
        "description": "Executed on the domain controller under an administrative
identity.",
        "source_ref": "indicator--ecc68121-91c7-4850-9701-2bf4528d729c",
        "target_ref": "indicator--95a923ae-16b6-4e1d-8b94-15cc0cf9cff9"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--f540ff66-0491-47a3-81d1-8af410e107a0",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096504Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096504Z",
        "relationship_type": "related-to",
        "description": "Ransomware deployment burst executed on this host via
hijacked PDQ Deploy.",
        "source_ref": "tool--0a98c94b-f5ff-4d8a-95ca-c2b138190267",
        "target_ref": "indicator--3baf56cb-7df7-4110-aff6-c66e8d1dc610"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--9ff74b30-83af-4546-862d-8058bf165ac9",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096673Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096673Z",
        "relationship_type": "uses",
        "description": "Ransomware mass-pushed via the hijacked enterprise
deployment tool.",
        "source_ref": "malware--171b2e59-a9ff-4faf-a5d3-00c7206d83d5",
        "target_ref": "tool--0a98c94b-f5ff-4d8a-95ca-c2b138190267"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--84d9f319-0ed3-4d22-b21b-aa7c7d90d9bf",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096804Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096804Z",
        "relationship_type": "uses",
        "description": "Implements the data-encryption impact technique.",
        "source_ref": "malware--171b2e59-a9ff-4faf-a5d3-00c7206d83d5",
        "target_ref": "attack-pattern--caf3a9f6-fde1-4656-81b8-285b5fec4495"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--ed69434a-8c93-4d6a-9000-e5f86e641a9a",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096934Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.096934Z",
        "relationship_type": "indicates",
        "description": "Observable confirming completed ransomware encryption
impact.",
        "source_ref": "indicator--e9b88618-1457-41cd-b1cb-23a22a77f15c",

```

```

        "target_ref": "attack-pattern--caf3a9f6-fde1-4656-81b8-285b5fec4495"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--f2c64d91-9ebe-482d-82e7-7dfb1e148da4",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.097059Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.097059Z",
        "relationship_type": "related-to",
        "description": "Ransom note left following encryption.",
        "source_ref": "malware--171b2e59-a9ff-4faf-a5d3-00c7206d83d5",
        "target_ref": "indicator--e9b88618-1457-41cd-b1cb-23a22a77f15c"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--b18ac012-4ea6-4457-a400-50a80aba5f47",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.097184Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.097184Z",
        "relationship_type": "uses",
        "description": "Advisory describes RAT injection into a legitimate process
for C2.",
        "source_ref": "malware--58055f21-6faf-4957-b2ac-7f2ad4feae3",
        "target_ref": "attack-pattern--1d6d531b-33e9-4cce-aad3-feda1494461d"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--1f08504b-dda0-4310-a11c-ae09bb467bac",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.097322Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.097322Z",
        "relationship_type": "related-to",
        "description": "Advisory-described exfiltration stage via legitimate cloud
storage (not independently re-verified in sim logs).",
        "source_ref": "malware--d4c5e297-426d-4584-b1c9-5aea5661db21",
        "target_ref": "attack-pattern--2b2bd5d7-5866-4bca-bbb7-32758be31015"
    },
    {
        "type": "relationship",
        "spec_version": "2.1",
        "id": "relationship--b7608880-b1a6-4cd5-bf33-b86473c3f401",
        "created": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.09745Z",
        "modified": "2026-08-28T23:02:44.09745Z",
        "relationship_type": "related-to",
        "description": "Consistent with RDP-proxy/tunnel or cloud-exfiltration
staging infrastructure.",
        "source_ref": "indicator--abf9216b-62d7-429b-93e5-efde40ff919a",
        "target_ref": "attack-pattern--a7151829-9c43-4348-8044-d09537e46cb6"
    }
}
]
}

```

8. MITRE ATT&CK Mapping

Tactic	Technique	ID
Initial Access	Drive-by Compromise	T1189
Execution	User Execution: Malicious File	T1204.002
Defense Evasion / Execution	System Binary Proxy Execution: Mshta	T1218.005
Execution	Command and Scripting Interpreter: PowerShell	T1059.001
Defense Evasion / Execution (analyst-added)	Trusted Developer Utilities Proxy Execution: MSBuild	T1127.001
Defense Evasion	Process Injection	T1055
Credential Access	OS Credential Dumping: LSASS Memory	T1003.001
Initial Access (parallel vector)	Exploit Public-Facing Application	T1190
Command and Control	Application Layer Protocol: Web Protocols	T1071.001
Lateral Movement	Remote Services: RDP	T1021.001
Exfiltration	Exfiltration Over Web Service: Cloud Storage	T1567.002
Impact	Data Encrypted for Impact	T1486

9. Impact & Containment

Impact: this attack grew from the compromise of a single computer into a company-wide ransomware incident. The attackers infected a user through a fake installer, kept a communication channel open to the infected computer, stole credentials, created an unauthorized account, compromised a Confluence server through a separate route, attempted remote access between systems, took control of a company software-deployment tool, spread ransomware using it, deleted the computer's built-in recovery copies, and encrypted company systems. The ransom note confirms the final stage succeeded. Containment steps, in priority order: (1) immediately isolate the three affected systems — CORP-WKS-102, SRV-CONFLUENCE-01, and corp-dc-01 — from the network, disconnecting them from the network rather than powering them off, since that better preserves evidence for further investigation; (2) disable the unauthorized backup account and investigate everywhere it was used; (3) change every credential that may have been reachable from the compromised computers; (4) replace the administrative credentials for the software-deployment tool, since the attackers had control of it; (5) patch or isolate the Confluence server; (6) block the attacker-controlled addresses at the network perimeter and check for any other computers that contacted them; (7) restrict remote-desktop access and require extra verification (MFA) for it; (8) set up monitoring specifically for unusual MSBuild internet activity and attempts to delete Windows recovery copies; (9) restore systems only from backups that were kept offline or otherwise protected from this attack; (10)

require that new software only be installed from an approved internal source, not downloaded directly from websites.

10. Conclusion & Recommendations

Final verdict: True Positive. This was a confirmed, multi-stage ransomware attack. It began with a single employee downloading a fake Zoom installer. The attackers then established a hidden communication channel with the infected computer, stayed inside the environment for several days, stole credentials, opened a second route into the network through the Confluence server, and attempted remote access between systems. Eventually, they took control of the company's own software-deployment tool, which let them spread ransomware across multiple computers. The ransom note confirms that the encryption stage completed successfully. One limitation of this investigation is noted openly rather than hidden: although PDQDeployService.exe was correctly identified as the tool used to spread the ransomware, its exact position in a very long, imperfectly-sorted list of 154 events could not be independently confirmed.

Recommendations:

1. Give strong, dedicated protection to any company-wide software-deployment tool (such as PDQ Deploy or similar systems), since gaining control of one tool like this can hand an attacker access to every computer it manages.
2. Set up alerts for MSBuild or other normally-trustworthy Windows tools making unexpected connections to the internet.
3. Regularly update and check internet-facing Confluence servers (and similar collaboration platforms) for known security weaknesses.
4. Store backups somewhere the attackers' compromised accounts cannot reach.
5. Only allow employees to install company software from an approved internal source, rather than downloading installers directly from websites — this would have stopped this attack at its very first step.

11. Evidence / Screenshots

Figure	Caption	Referenced in
Figure 1	The platform's own threat write-up: header, summary, and description of the threat group and how the attack unfolds	Section 5
Figure 2	The endpoint tool's overview panel (process history, activity timeline, flagged behaviors, and network activity), with ordinary Outlook traffic visible	Section 5

	alongside it	
Figure 3	The endpoint tool's process history, expanded: the full chain from the initial download through the second-stage program	Tasks 1,2,3,4,6
Figure 4	The security-alert panel: every rule that fired, with a summary of severity and sources	Section 4
Figure 5	The network-activity panel listing the confirmed malicious addresses alongside the ordinary Microsoft/Office 365 traffic that was reviewed and ruled out	Section 5
Figure 6	The Task 10 confirmed-finding panel showing the accepted ransom-note answer	Task 10
Figure 7	The operation-completion screen: all 10 tasks answered correctly	Section 3
Figure 8	The security log's failed-login entry showing the outside address 92.51.2.27 and the targeted account (adriana.garcia on CORP-WKS-102), with the reason given as an incorrect password	Task 5
Figure 9	The detailed script-activity log entry showing the credential-stealing script's full file path and the command it ran	Task 7
Figure 10	The account-creation log entry confirming the unauthorized "backup" account was created on the Confluence server	Task 8
Figure 11	The activity-timeline entry showing the company's own software-deployment tool starting on the affected computer just before the	Task 9

	ransomware spread	
--	-------------------	--

Figure 1. The platform's own threat write-up: header, summary, and description of the threat group and how the attack unfolds.

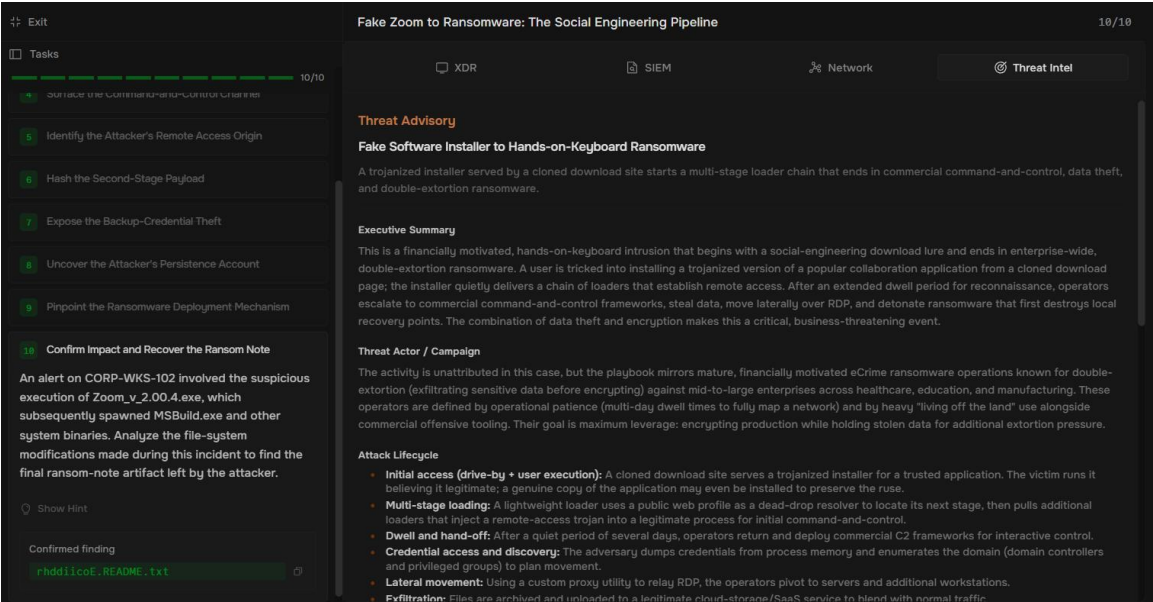


Figure 2. The endpoint tool's overview panel (process history, activity timeline, flagged behaviors, and network activity), with ordinary Outlook traffic visible alongside it.

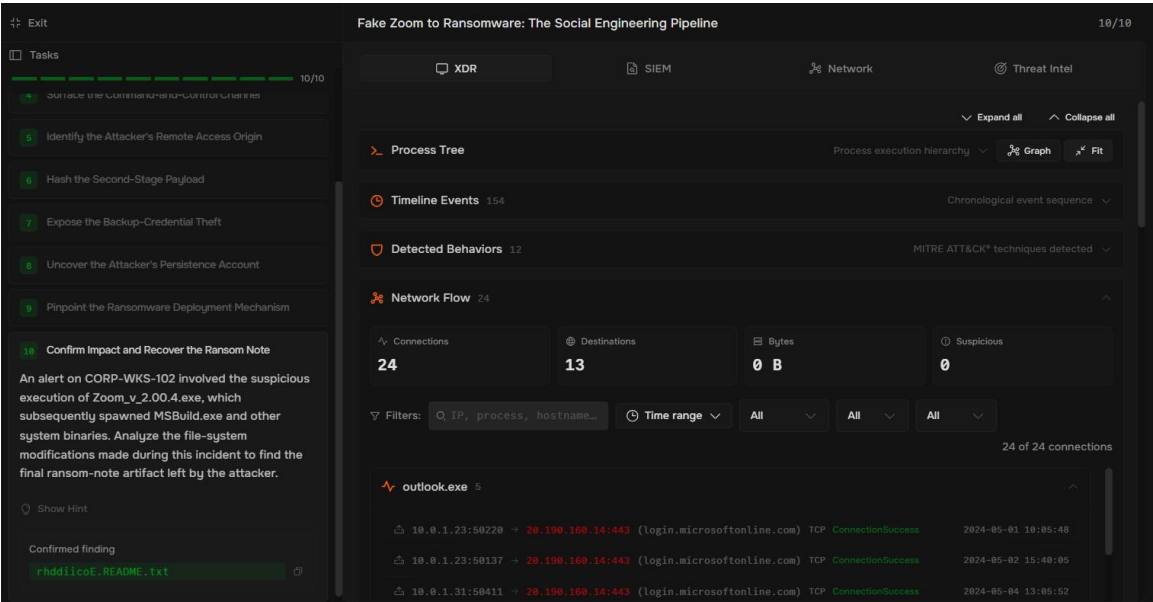


Figure 3. The endpoint tool's process history, expanded: the full chain from the initial download through the second-stage program, including Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe's fingerprint, mshta.exe, MSBuild.exe, and ZoomUpdater.exe.

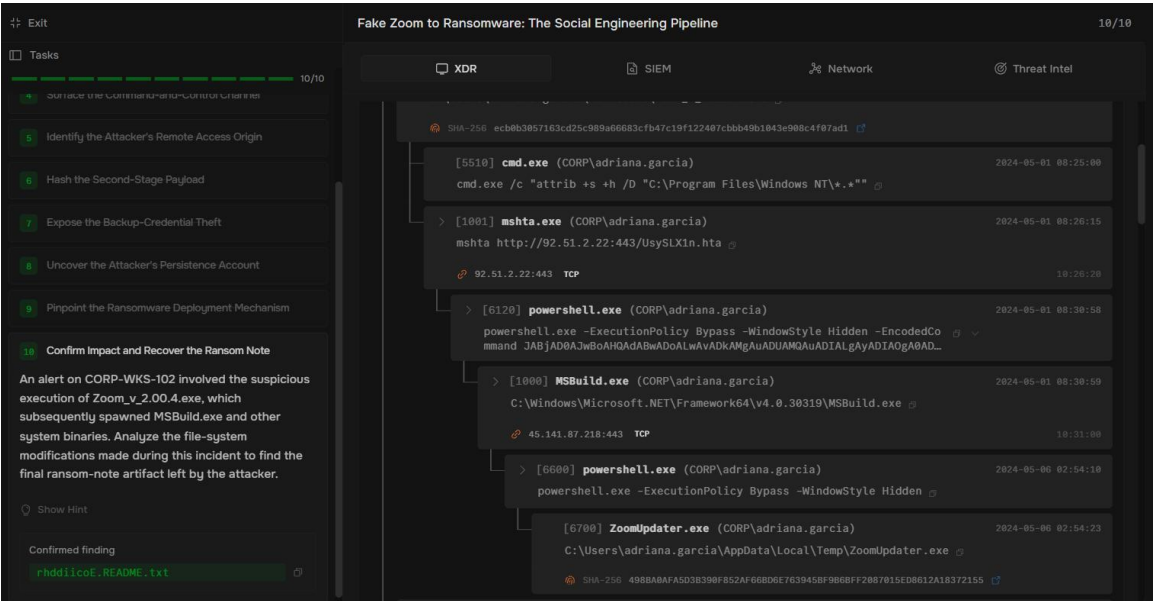


Figure 4. The security-alert panel: every rule that fired, with a summary of severity and sources.

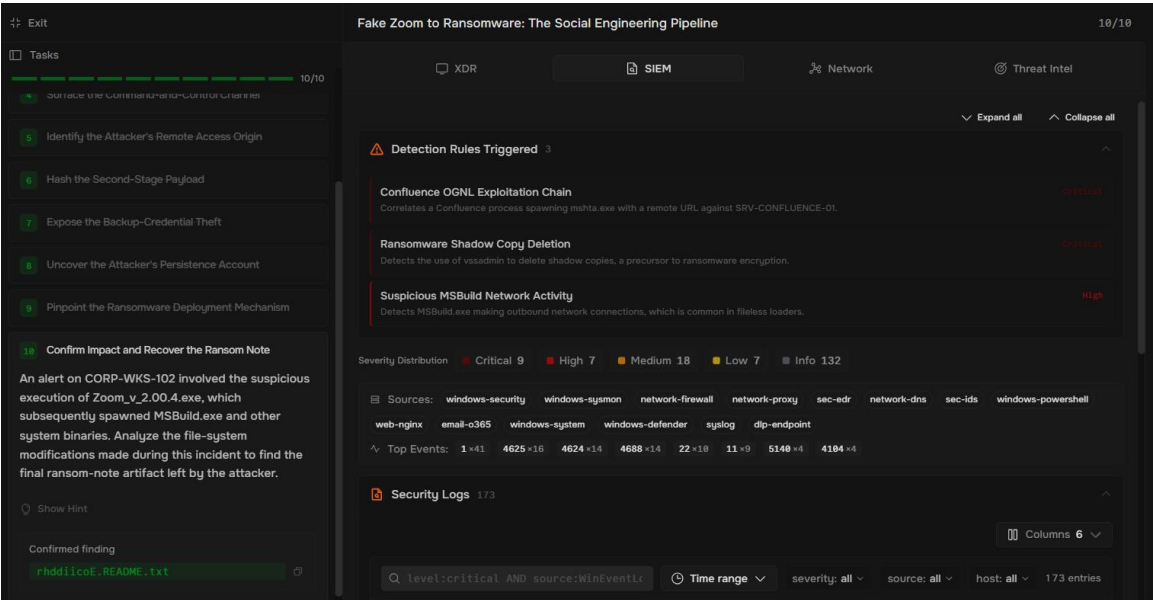


Figure 5. The network-activity panel listing the confirmed malicious addresses alongside the ordinary Microsoft/Office 365 traffic that was reviewed and ruled out.

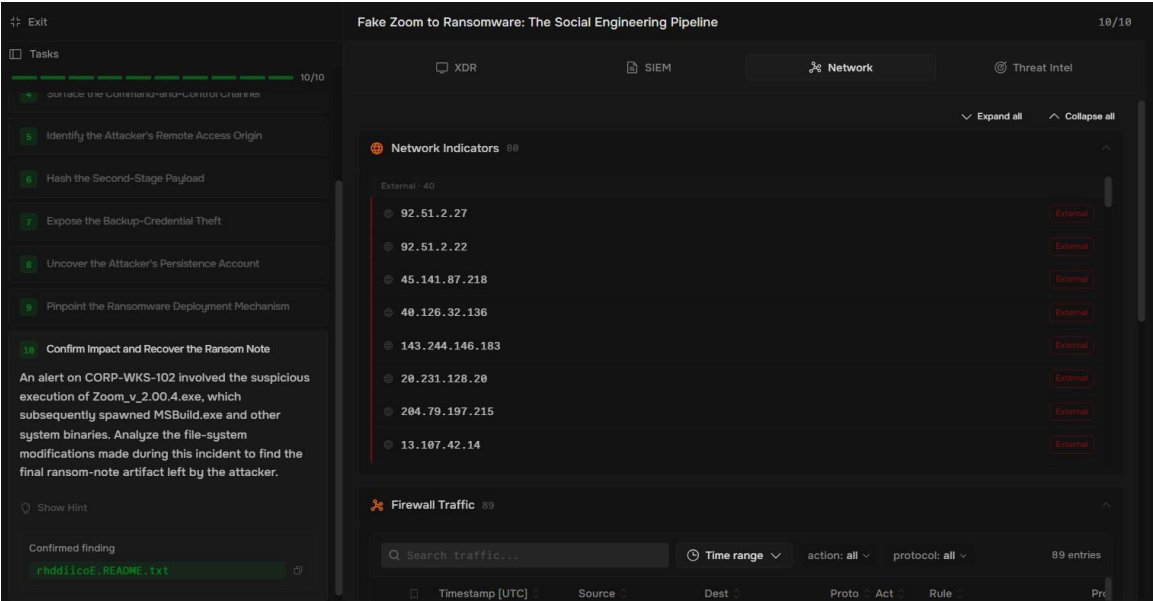


Figure 6. The Task 10 confirmed-finding panel showing the accepted answer, rhddiicoE.README.txt.

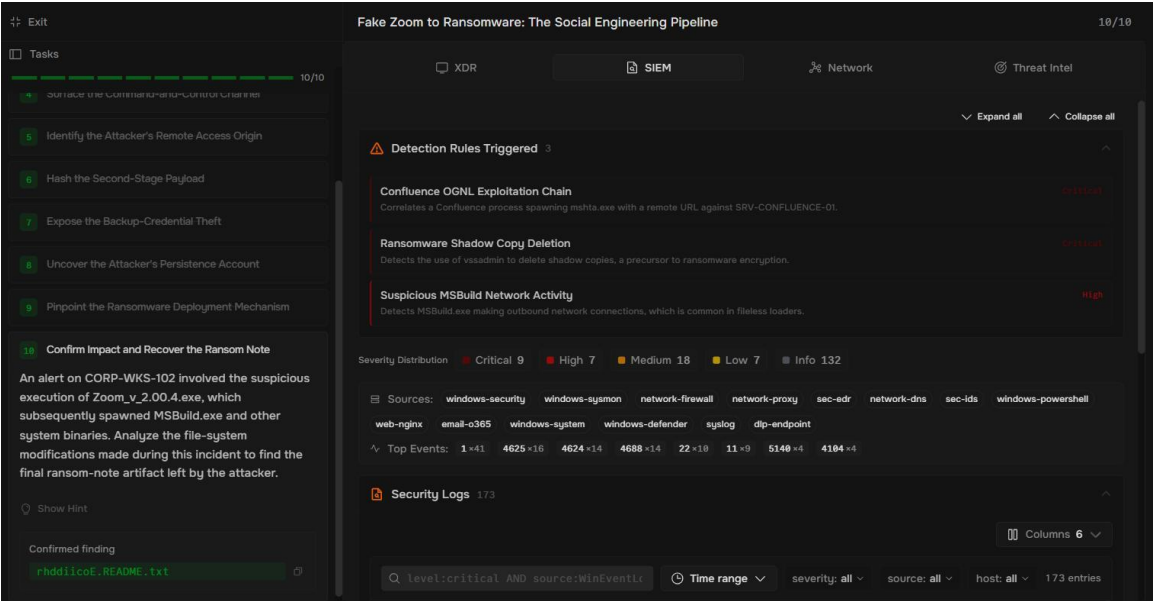


Figure 7. The operation-completion screen: all 10 tasks answered correctly, ranked #2 that week.

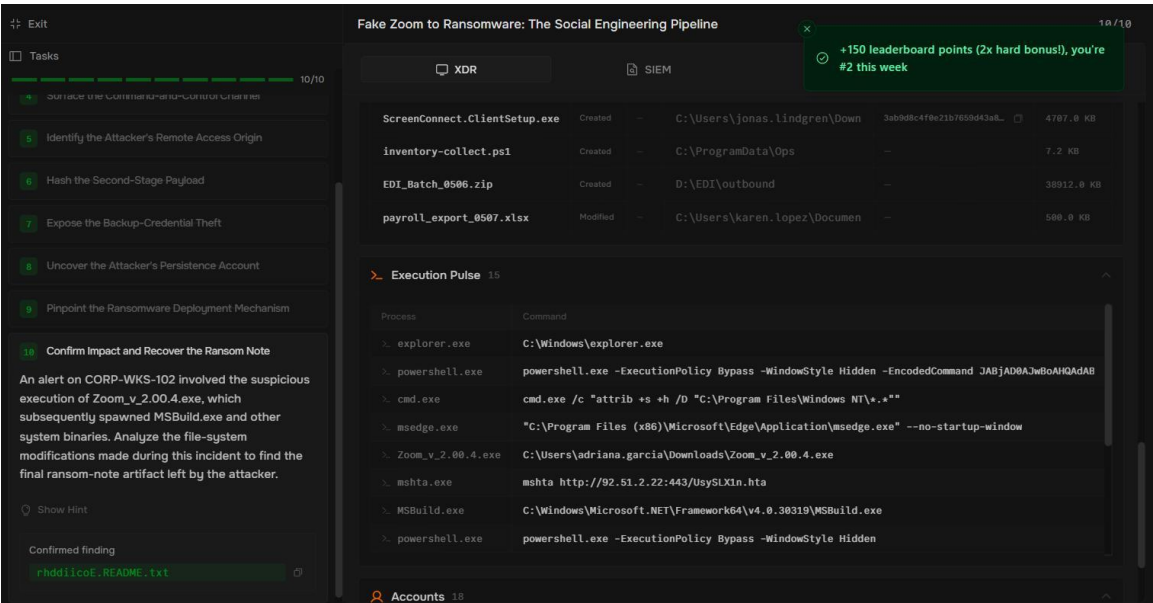


Figure 8. The security log's failed-login entry: the outside address 92.51.2.27 attempting to log on to adriana.garcia's account on CORP-WKS-102, rejected for an incorrect password.

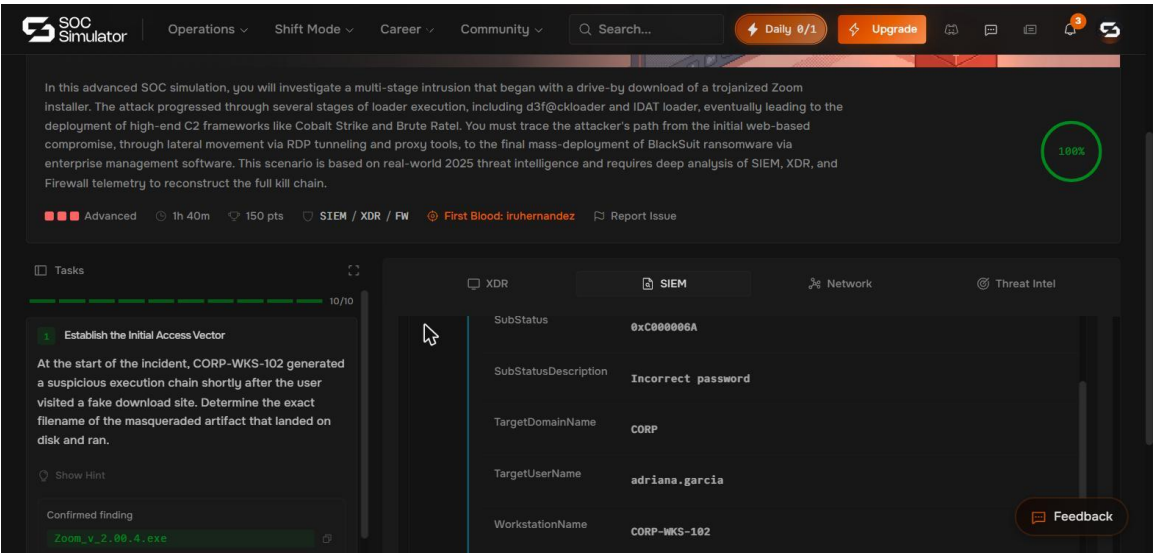


Figure 9. The detailed script-activity log entry showing the full file path (C:\Users\backup\Veeam-Get-Creds-New.ps1) and the command used to pull credentials out of memory.

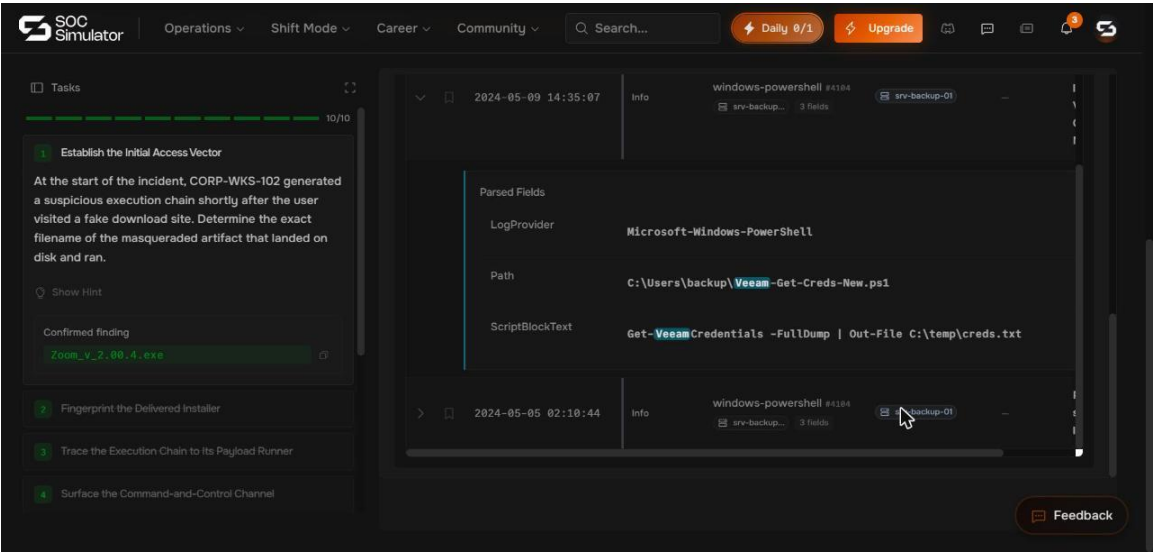


Figure 10. The account-creation log entry: a new account named "backup" created on the Confluence server (SRV-CONFLUENCE-01).

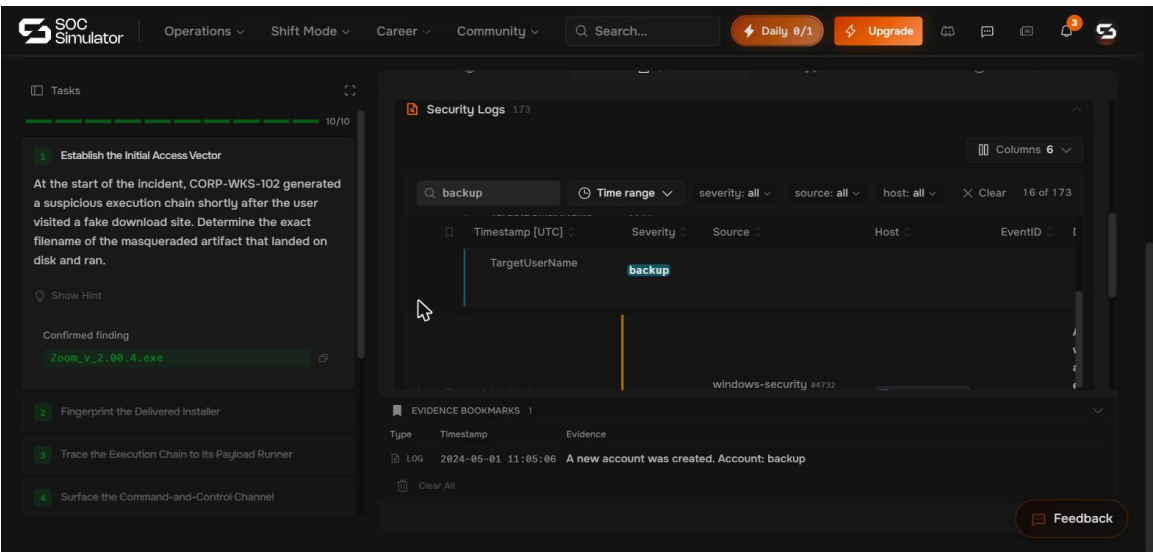


Figure 11. The activity-timeline entry showing PDQDeployService.exe — the company's own software-deployment tool — starting on CORP-WKS-102 at 23:58:12, just before the ransomware spread company-wide.

SOC Simulator

Operations

Shift Mode

Career

Community

Search...

Daily 0/1

Upgrade

Tasks

10/10

1 Establish the Initial Access Vector

At the start of the incident, CORP-WKS-102 generated a suspicious execution chain shortly after the user visited a fake download site. Determine the exact filename of the masqueraded artifact that landed on disk and ran.

Show Hint

Confirmed finding

Zoom_v_2.00.4.exe

2 Fingerprint the Delivered Installer

3 Trace the Execution Chain to Its Payload Runner

4 Surface the Command-and-Control Channel

XDR

SIEM

Network

Threat Intel

PDQDeploy

Time range

severity: all

type: all

Clear

1 of 154

Timestamp [UTC]	Severity	Type	Endpoint	Description
2024-05-09 23:58:12	Medium	Process	CORP-WKS-102	Process started: PDQDeployService.exe on CORP-WKS-102

EVIDENCE BOOKMARKS 1

Type	Timestamp	Evidence
LOG	2024-05-01 11:05:06	A new account was created. Account: backup

Clear All

Feedback